

In the quiet hush of an empty theater, Alex stands center stage with eyes closed, breathing slowly. Dawn's light filters through the windows, casting long shadows of the velvet curtain and rows of vacant seats. In this tranquil moment before rehearsal, every small sound is amplified – the soft tap of Alex's leather shoe on the wooden floor, the distant clank of a heating pipe, and the steady tick-tock of a metronome app.

Sitting in the front row, Sam lounges comfortably among the empty chairs, sipping a cup of strong coffee. Sam's voice breaks the silence, casual and warm: "You ready to roll, Alex?" He draws out the last word playfully, his drawl reverberating in the open hall. Alex opens his eyes and smiles slightly, turning toward his friend. "Almost," Alex replies, stretching his arms overhead until his shoulders give a quiet crack. "I want to go through my warm-ups first. My tongue still feels tangled."

Sam chuckles and gives an encouraging nod. "Go for it. I'm all ears." He cups a hand behind his ear in an exaggerated gesture. Alex laughs under his breath, then inhales deeply, standing tall. In a clear but gentle voice, he begins a favorite warm-up passage, a descriptive monologue learned long ago:

"In solemn silence, by the silver sea,
a lone soul sings soft soliloquy."

His voice starts soft on the first line and crescendos on the second, filling the theater with rich resonance. The alliteration of the "s" sound in "solemn silence" and "silver sea" slides off his tongue smoothly. Alex enunciates every word with care – from the initial "s" in "solemn" and "silence" to the gentle "l" and drawn-out long "ee" vowel in "sea," capturing a wistful, windy whisper of the imaginary scene.

Sam claps lightly, the sound echoing in the hall. "Lovely," he says with a mischievous grin. "Now let's try a classic tongue twister." Without missing a beat, he articulates clearly: "Peter Piper picked a peck of pickled peppers." He overemphasizes each **P** – pop, pop, pop – daring Alex to follow suit.

Alex takes a deep breath and gives it a go: "Peter Piper picked a peck of pickled peppers." He manages to hit each popping **P** and crisp **K** sound without stumbling. Feeling bold, he tries again in one breath: "PeterPiperpickedapeckofpickledpeppers!" The phrase comes out in a rush and he nearly tangles his tongue halfway through. Alex breaks into laughter, shaking his head. "Whew, almost had it that time," he chuckles.

"Bravo!" Sam calls out, beaming. "Feeling warmed up yet, or do you want another?"

Alex is already smiling, his voice and lips loosening up. "One more, please. Something with tricky mixes."

Sam thinks for a moment, stirring the last sip of his coffee, and then his eyes light up. In a dramatic, mock-serious tone, he intones: "The sixth sick sheik's sixth sheep's sick." He bursts

into laughter at the end, nearly spilling his coffee. “That one always twists my tongue,” he admits, wiping a drop of coffee from his chin.

Alex raises an eyebrow with determination. “Oh, that’s a tough one. Let me try.” He plants his feet firmly as if preparing for battle, then carefully articulates: “The sixth... sick... sheik’s... sixth... sheep’s... sick.” The sequence of “s,” “sh,” and “th” sounds is indeed a minefield. The rapid shifts make him stumble at first. The first attempt comes out garbled—“The sixth shi... the sixth s-” Alex stops and starts again, slowing down. “The sixth sick sheik’s sixth sheep’s sick.” This time, each word is distinct. Then he laughs, throwing up his hands. “Wow, that one was tricky, but I got it!”

Now adequately warmed up, Alex rolls his shoulders and shakes out his hands. The next part of his routine is a rhyming exercise he likes to perform to practice intonation and rhythm. He clears his throat and begins a whimsical impromptu rhyme:

“I knew a knight who knew the night,
wandering fearless under waning light.”

He takes a sip of water from a bottle on the stage floor. Satisfied that even the trickiest sounds are flowing smoothly now, he decides to push his luck with one more playful phrase. “I treasure the pleasure of leisure beyond measure,” he recites clearly, pronouncing each word slowly. The internal rhyme and gentle buzz of those consonants make the sentence roll off his tongue with ease—far more easily than it might have a few minutes ago.

Finally, Alex turns to a page in the script lying on a nearby stool. “Alright, moment of truth,” he says, suddenly a bit more serious. The script is an original play, rich with varied language. He picks a random paragraph from his monologue — a particularly florid one he struggled with the day before — and reads aloud to test his tongue’s agility:

“Through perilous peaks and cavernous deeps our hero perseveres; neither thunderous storm nor treacherous terrain can shatter his spirit. In quest of truth he conquers fear and declares: ‘I shall emerge ardent and pure, sure in my purpose, carrying hope’s flame no night can dim.’”

His voice rings out confidently as the words echo in the empty theater. When he finishes, the theater falls back to silence for a beat. Then Sam breaks into genuine applause, the sound of his hands ringing against the auditorium’s walls. “That was awesome!” he calls out, beaming. “Every sound from A to Z – I think you’ve got them all now.”

Alex steps down from the stage and joins Sam in the front row, finally taking a seat and exhaling with satisfaction. “That felt good,” he admits, out of breath but clearly happy. He picks up the coffee for a final sip – it’s lukewarm and bitter, but it tastes like victory.

They sit together in a companionable silence, watching motes of dust dance in the slanting light. Alex feels ready for rehearsal, his voice warmed up and prepared to bring the words on the page to life.